

CHAPTER 8

OFFICERS WITH REAL NAMES

'If you have done no crime, you have nothing to worry.'

At the Pallipuram camp, I was taken to a room where a CBI officer introduced himself as superintendent R S Dhankar, the CBI's chief investigating officer in the ISRO spy case. He showed me his identity card. It was a refreshing change from the IB's shady ways. I instantly thought that he was a good person.

Dhankar asked me to sit on a cot before leaving the room. I was left with an ageing police constable who introduced himself as Darshan Singh. A genial man in his late fifties, Singh remained with me throughout my stay here, attending to every need of mine. This god-fearing man gave me strength to face the rest of the interrogation. He would console me, never getting tired of repeating that the truth will eventually come out.

On 5 December, around 2 pm, I had my first lunch in three days (I had stopped taking food on 2 December, while being tortured by the IB officials at Latex Guest House). By now I realised that all the accused in the case were here. In fact, it was a big hall, partitioned with curtains.

In the adjacent portion were Chandrasekhar and Sasikumaran. The two Maldivian women would be somewhere in the building, I knew.

Finishing my lunch, I sat on the cot, my left hand cuffed to the leg of the furniture. Could they have arrested more people in the fictitious case, I wondered. Who could have been behind this sordid drama? My thoughts were interrupted by a man who briskly walked into the room.